

Lexus NX300h technology, drive review: A different flavour of luxury

The Lexus NX300h is not everyone's cup of tea, it is actually an intriguing evening cocktail served with all the flair in the world.

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hole here with a leather lid, and a leather armrest that opens up to another storage area with a folding Qi wireless charging pad, a 12V power socket, an aux port and two USB ports.

LEXUS HYBRID DRIVE TECHNOLOGY

The Lexus Hybrid Drive technology pairs a 2.5-litre petrol engine that produces

transmission) gearbox, which is smooth. We averaged 15.6kmpl in our tests spread over four days. The Lexus E-Four permanent all-wheel-drive system does not link the rear axle to the front with a mechanical prop shaft, which in turn again makes the car more efficient on overall terms.

INFOTAINMENT, AUDIO AND ELECTRONICS

Media playback includes MiraCast, but no Apple CarPlay/Android Auto. This is a system that isn't as inviting as others, so we did miss the aforementioned two.

You get a fantastic, 14-speaker Mark Levinson sound system with Clari-fi - a digital audio upscaling engine.

The instrument cluster is analogue, and the MID is easy to operate via the steering wheel. You get three-step seat cooling and heating for the front seats, and heating for the rear bench. The rear seats are electrically operable and are 60:40 split. The tailgate is electronic and has the handsfree open feature that seemed reliable here. There's also a 360-degree camera and an HUD that's pretty handy, and a steering heater that isn't going to be used frequently in India.

DRIVE AND RIDE QUALITY

The Lexus NX300h delivers linear power, and is not the fastest car around. It is smooth, and NVH levels are well refined. You get a bit of tyre noise in EV mode, although the engine is nicely refined, and never really bothers you. The e-CVT gearbox is really smooth, and that is paired with Lexus' Adaptive Variable Suspension (AVS) to give you customisable suspension balance for different terrains. While it does stiffen up in Dynamic mode, it is still a bit on the softer side of things, which means a few undulations in slightly aberrant highway stretches, and a bit of lateral movement. Surprisingly, though, the NX struggled with deep city potholes a fair bit, with a lot of abrupt body movement. It handles well around corners, with minimal body roll. It feels solid and planted.

FINAL VERDICT

The Lexus NX300h is not be the most conventional choice, but if you do make the choice (and we think you should), you will keep falling in love with it over time. **d**



BUILD, DESIGN AND AESTHETICS

Say what you may, but there's no ignoring the Lexus NX300h. It is not conventionally beautiful, but there's something about it that makes you feel like you can't ever have enough of it.

The C-pillar is very sharply angled, and the high-mounted rear spoiler lip creates a nice design element. The Lexus NX has ample road presence, buoyed by its proportionate tailgate.

Inside, the jagged edges are retained in the dashboard layout. At the top of the central column sits a 10.3-inch non-touchscreen infotainment display, offering decent legibility but reflecting upon incident sunlight. All the controls, the semi-analogue clock and the buttons are set against an outward-sloping dark plastic panel and lined with silver plastic bezel along the column's sides.

The typical Toyota-layout gearknob is joined by a large, laptop-like trackpad that offers haptic feedback. There is a storage

- **Price:** ₹53.33 lac;
- **Powertrain:** 2.5-litre, 4-cylinder turbocharged petrol engine, 151kW permanent magnet synchronous electric motor, e-CVT gearbox;
- **Fuel economy:** 14.8kmpl (obtained);
- **Pros:** Quirky looks, unusual take on luxury, class-leading audio performance, good aesthetics, feature-loaded, economical and efficient;
- **Cons:** Design quirks may be a bit too much for everyone, ride quality is a bit irregular, not the strongest power delivery;

153 bhp with two electric motors to produce total power output of 195 bhp and 210 Nm torque. The rear electric motor is connected to the front motor and the engine by a wire, which sends impulses to control the rear axle and tell it when to work. This also makes it an intelligent, permanent all-wheel-drive car.

The hybrid drivetrain is also paired to an e-CVT (continuously variable